EXPLAINED SIMPLY · PAYMENTS

What happens when you click "Pay"

A few seconds. Several companies. No money moves yet.

You click Pay
on the store's checkout

↓

Payment provider
Stripe, PayPal, Adyen...

↓

Card network
Visa, Mastercard...

↓

Your bank says yes or no

Swipe for all 7 steps →

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01

Your card number skips the store.

On a well-built checkout, the card form belongs to the payment provider (Stripe, PayPal, Adyen and others). Your card details go straight to them. The store gets a token, like a coat-check ticket.

FOR DEVELOPERS

Card data that never touches your server means far fewer PCI rules for you.

02

The provider calls your bank through Visa or Mastercard.

The card network is the road. Your bank, the one that gave you the card, is the one who decides.

FOR DEVELOPERS

Store → provider (and its acquiring bank) → network → issuing bank.

03

Your bank decides in seconds.

Is the card valid? Do the details match? Is there enough money or credit? Does this look like fraud?

FOR STORE OWNERS

When the answer is no, you often get only a generic reason. Many declines are not your website's fault.

04

Sometimes your bank asks: “Is this really you?”

The app prompt or SMS code is called 3-D Secure. It comes from your bank, not the store. In Europe and the UK it is often required.

FOR DEVELOPERS

Your checkout must handle this extra step, or those payments fail.

05

"Approved" can mean a hold, not money moved.

Your bank reserves the amount and your available balance drops. Many stores collect it right away. Others, like hotels, hold now and collect later.

FOR DEVELOPERS

Authorize now, capture when you ship. Online card holds usually last about 7 days. Capture inside that window.

06

The money arrives days later.

After capture, funds move from your bank to the store’s payment provider, then to the store’s bank account. Usually within a few days, longer for new accounts.

FOR STORE OWNERS

Today’s sales are not in your bank account today. Plan cash flow for that.

07

Where checkouts go wrong.

A double-click on “Pay” must not charge twice. A customer may close the tab before the “Thank you” page.

FOR DEVELOPERS

Send the same idempotency key for the same order and disable the button after one click. Confirm orders from the provider’s webhook, not the thank-you page.

RECAP

One click, six steps.

1. Card details go to the provider. Store gets a token.
2. Provider → card network → your bank.
3. Your bank says yes or no.
4. Maybe: “Is this really you?”
5. Approved = a hold until it’s captured.
6. Money reaches the store days later.

Save this for your next checkout project.

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